

Atomic Habits

**An Easy & Proven Way to
Build Good Habits & Break Bad Ones**

Based on the book by James Clear

2002

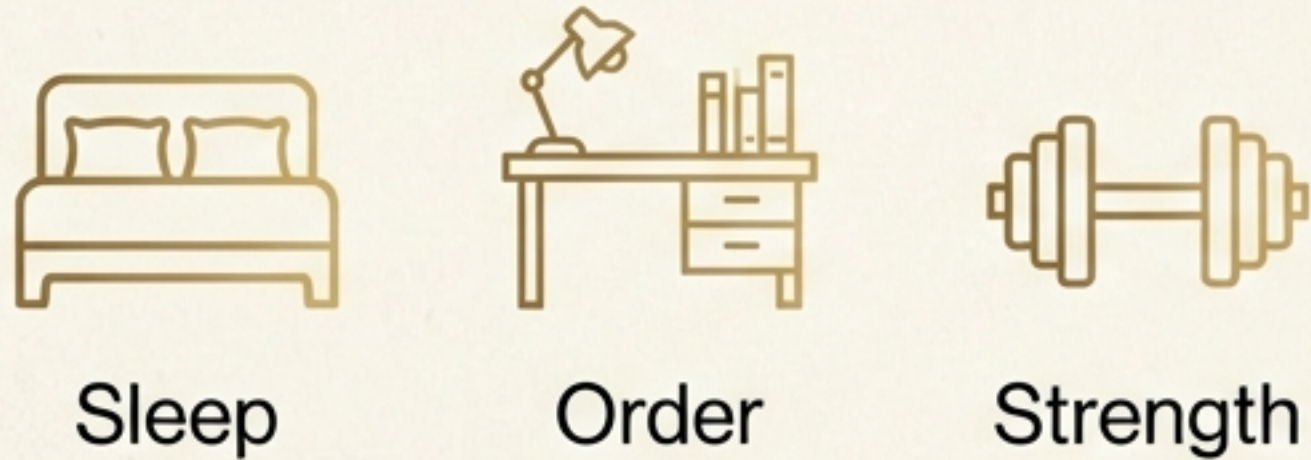
The Injury

On the final day of his sophomore year, James Clear was hit in the face with a baseball bat. The impact crushed his nose into a U-shape and sent his brain slamming into his skull.

- Multiple skull fractures.
- Two shattered eye sockets.
- Placed into a medically induced coma.
- Woke up unable to smell; blowing his nose pushed his left eye out of its socket.

This was the starting line. No immediate success, only a long road of recovery.

The Recovery



2 years later: Building control
through routine.



6 Years Later (2008)

- **ESPN Academic All-America Team**
- **Awarded the President's Medal**

There wasn't one defining moment... It was a gradual evolution, a long series of small wins and tiny breakthroughs.

The Aggregation of Marginal Gains



In 2003, British Cycling was mediocre. In 110 years, no British cyclist had won the Tour de France. Manufacturers refused to sell them bikes for fear of hurting their brand.

Helvetica Now Display
The Catalyst: Dave Brailsford.

The whole principle came from the idea that if you broke down everything you could think of that goes into riding a bike, and then improve it by 1 percent, you will get a significant increase when you put them all together.

Searching for 1% Helvetica Now Display

Redesigned bike
seats for comfort.

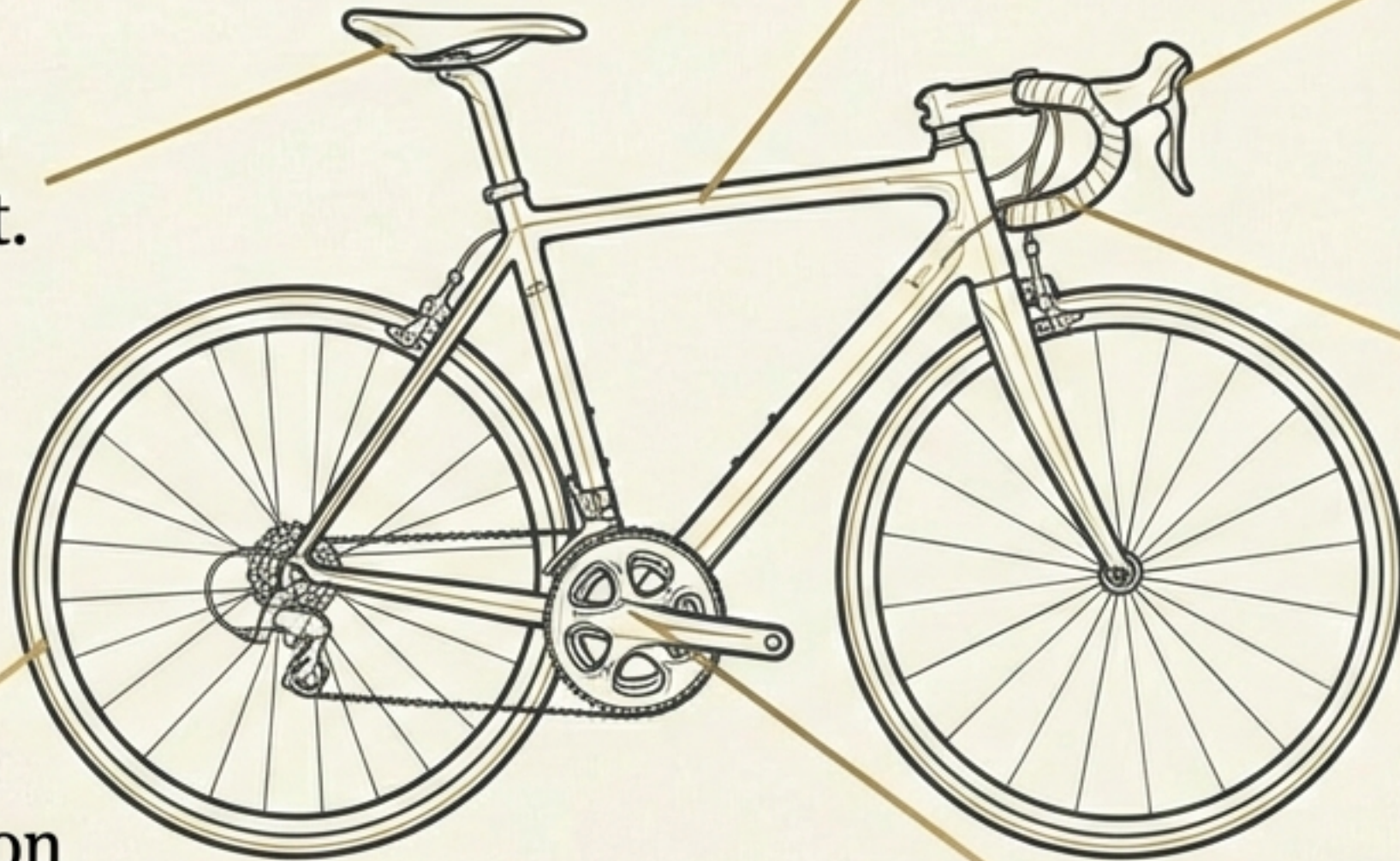
Painted inside of team
truck white to spot dust.

Surgeon hired to teach
proper hand-washing
(reduced flu risk).

Tested massage gels
for fastest recovery.

Rubbed alcohol on
tires for better grip.

Electrically heated overshorts
to maintain muscle temp.



The Result of Aggregation

60%

of available Georgia Pro
of available gold medals won
at 2008 Beijing Olympics.

9 Olympic / 7 World

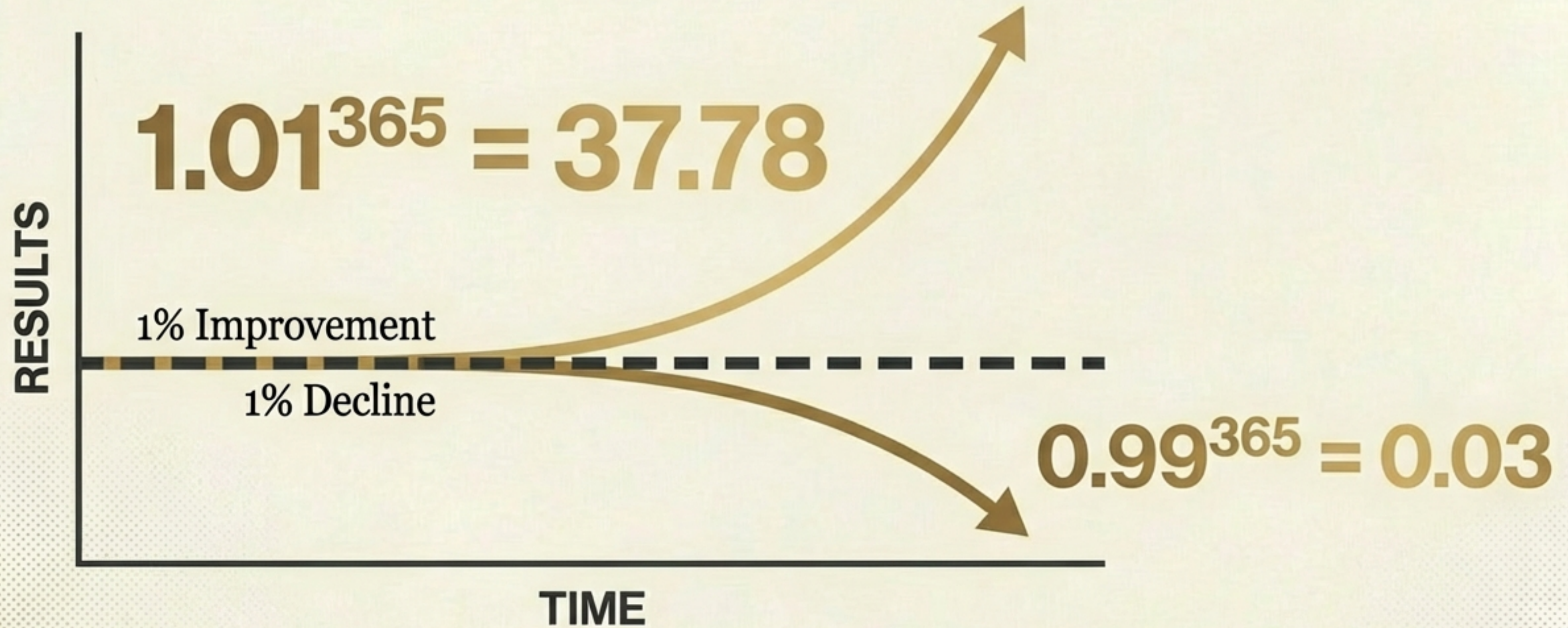
Records set at 2012 London Olympics.

5 in 6

Tour de France victories
(2012, 2013, 2015, 2016, 2017).

**Total Dominance (2007–2017):
178 World Championships
& 66 Gold Medals.**

The Math of 1%



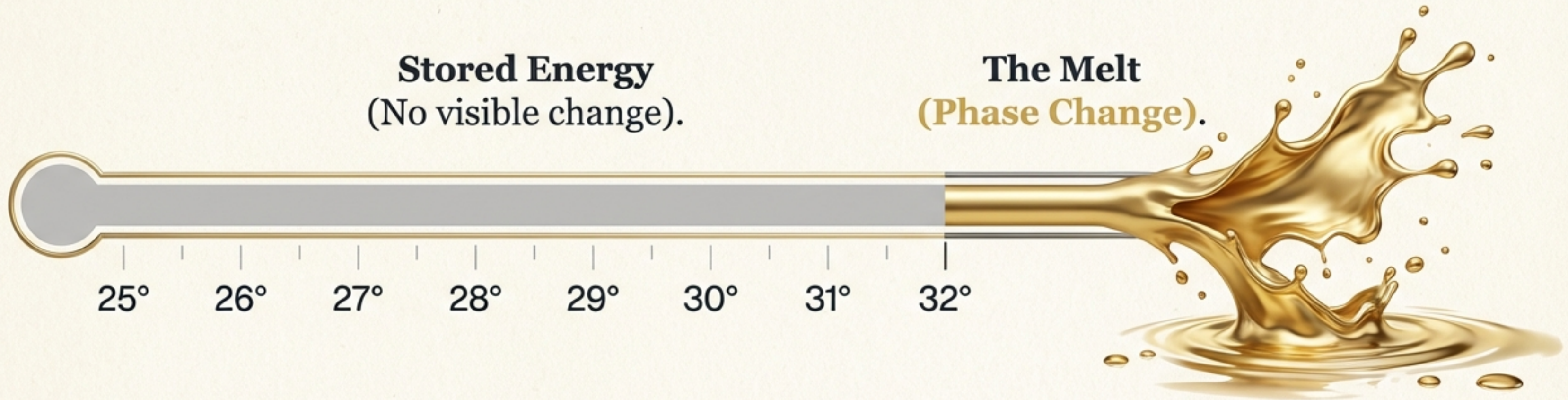
Habits are the compound interest of self-improvement.

Outcomes are a Lagging Measure

The Habit (Current Trajectory)	The Lagging Measure (Outcome)
Financial Habits	Net Worth
Eating Habits	Weight
Learning Habits	Knowledge
Cleaning Habits	Clutter

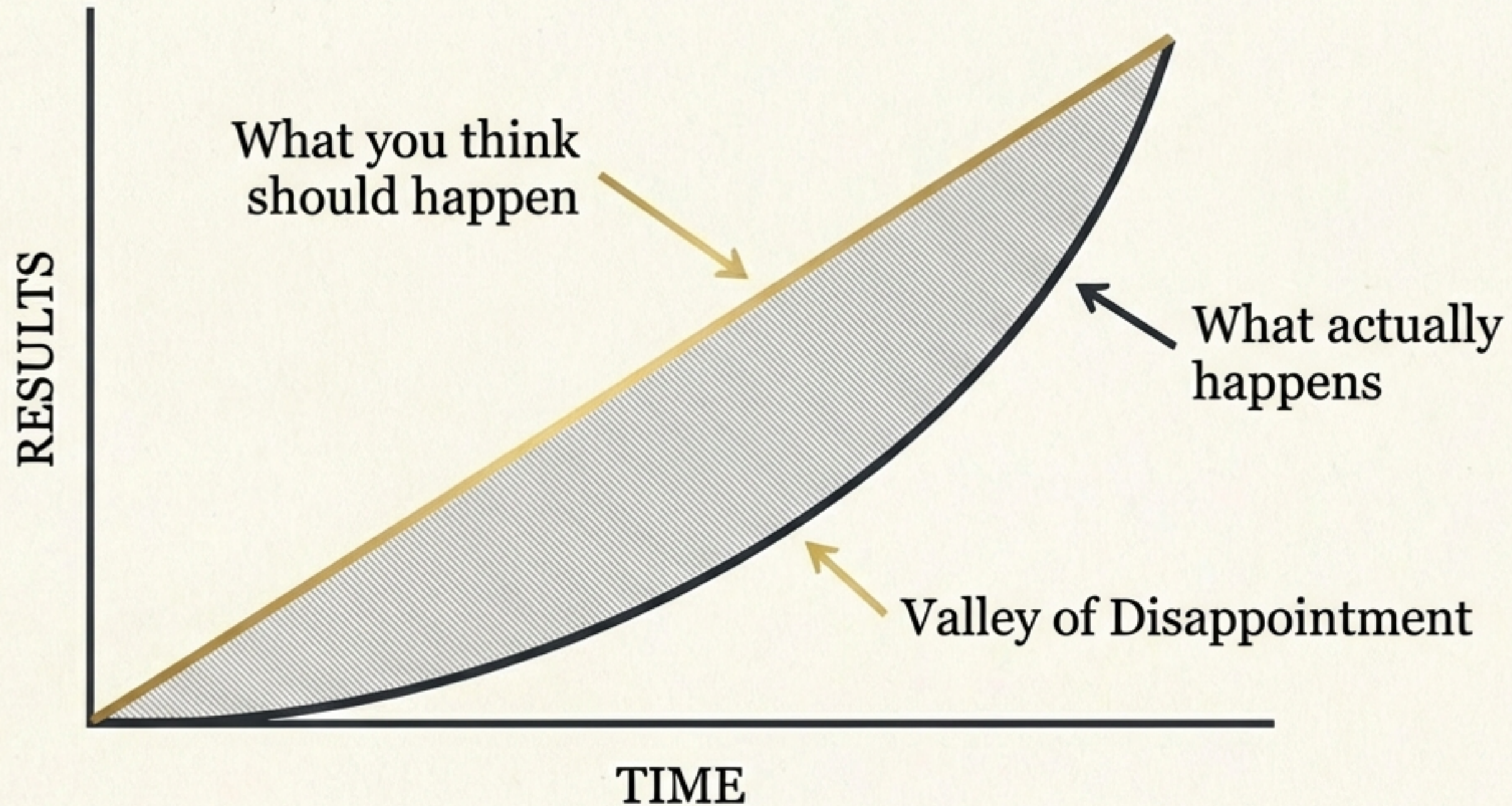
You should be far more concerned with your current trajectory than with your current results.

The Ice Cube Analogy



Complaining about working hard without success is like complaining an ice cube isn't melting at 31 degrees. The work wasn't wasted. It was stored.

The Plateau of Latent Potential



Forget About Goals. Focus on Systems.

GOALS



The results you want to achieve.

Winning the championship.

SYSTEMS



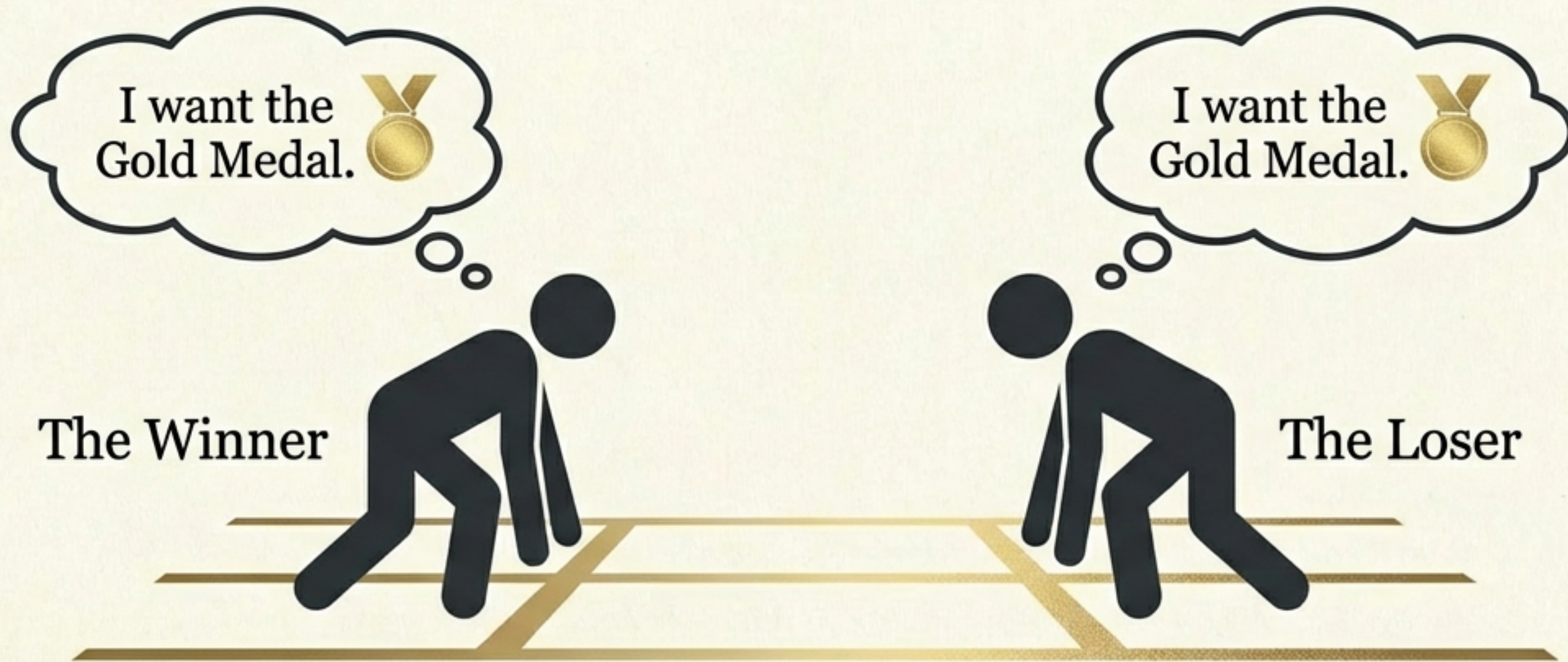
The processes that lead to results.

Your practice schedule.

**You do not rise to the level of your goals.
You fall to the level of your systems.**

Problem #1: Survivorship Bias

Winners and Losers Have the Same Goals.



If successful and unsuccessful people share the same goal, then the goal cannot be the thing that differentiates them.

Problem #2: Momentary Change



Fix the inputs and the outputs will fix themselves.

Problem #3 & #4

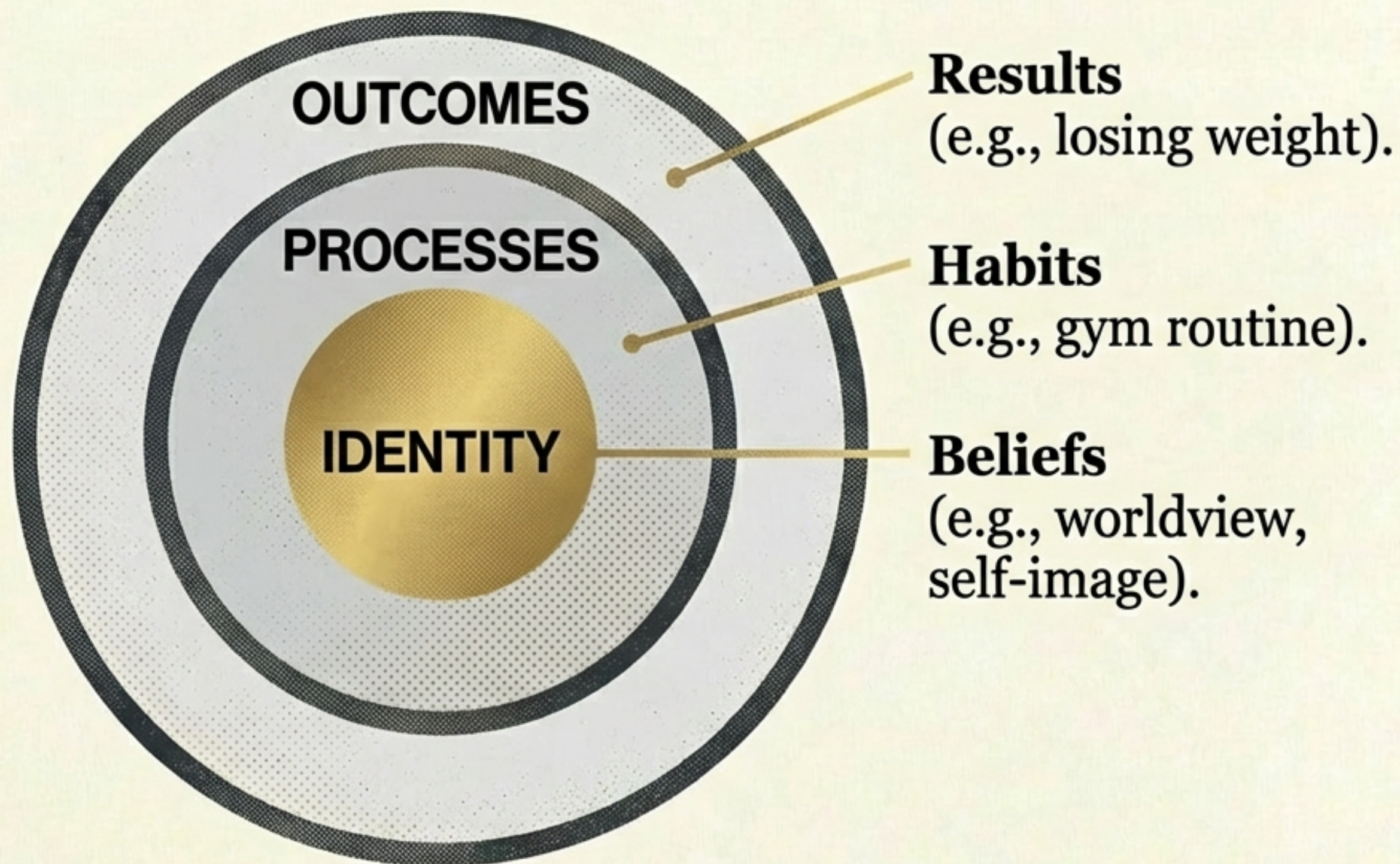
The Happiness Trap

Goals create an “either-or” **conflict**. You are either a success or a failure. You postpone happiness until the next milestone.

The Yo-Yo Effect

Goals are temporary. When the race ends, the motivation stops. True long-term thinking is goal-less thinking; it's about the cycle of endless refinement.

The Three Layers of Behavior Change



True change happens from the center out.

Identity-Based Habits

Person A

“No thanks. I’m trying to quit.”

Still believes they are a smoker trying to be something else.

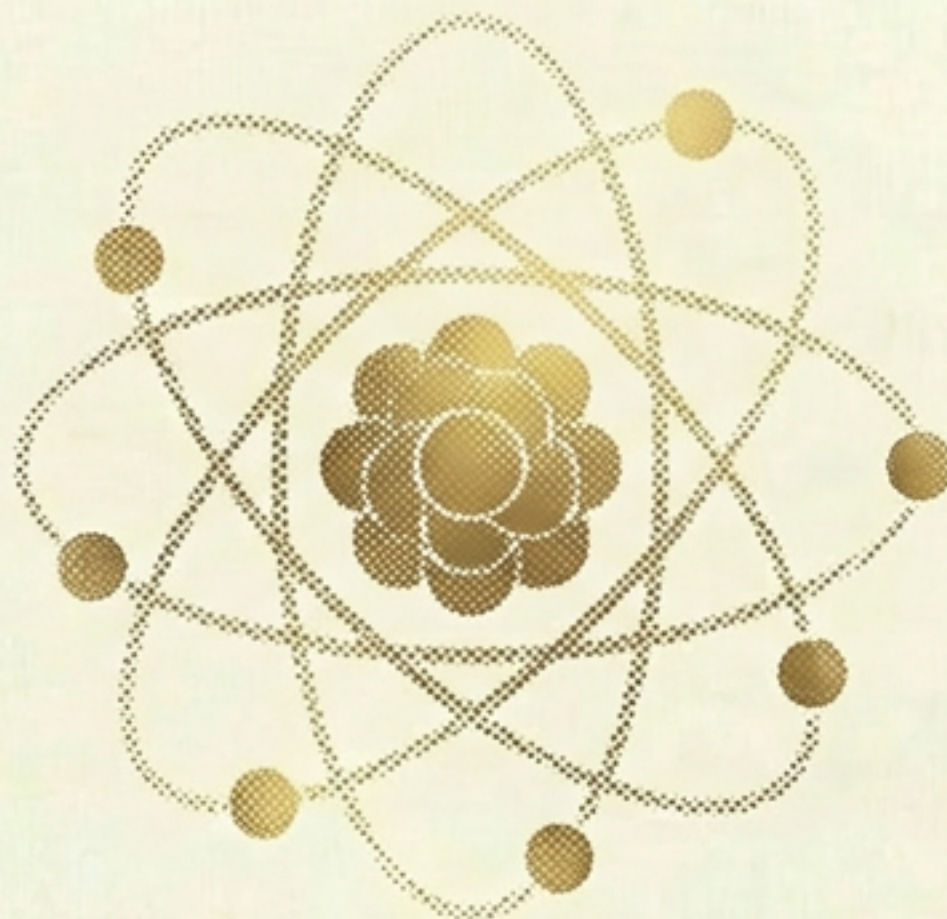
Person B

“No thanks. I’m not a smoker.”

A shift in identity.
Smoking is part of their former life.

The goal is not to run a marathon, the goal is to become a runner.

What is an Atomic Habit?



1. A tiny change, a marginal gain, a 1 percent improvement.
2. A fundamental unit of a larger system.

Just as atoms are the building blocks of molecules, atomic habits are the building blocks of remarkable results.